

The women, on the other hand, would have been contemplating both their recent past and their immediate future. Having missed the Paris bus, there is an air of uncertainty amidst a renewed clamour for an overhaul of personnel. The emotional outburst by coach Janneke Schopman at the end of the home leg in Rourkela, followed by her resignation, only made it worse for a team that is still coming to terms with its situation.

Post the Asian Games high, the men's team had sobering outings in Valencia and South Africa. The mixed results in the two events hinted that the team still had a lot of work to do in pursuit of Olympic glory. The Pro League at home, while indicating the team's strengths, reaffirmed the areas of concern — finding ways to score past stubborn defences when denied penalty corners being the most important one.

India scored 20 goals in eight games, winning three outright ones and two in shootouts, with 11 of the goals coming off penalty corners (PC). India's riches in terms of their PC batteries — led by Harmanpreet Singh (**below right**) and including Jugraj and Amit Rohidas with Arajit Hundal in the ranks — make it obvious for them to explore that as the main scoring option.

Yet, as Ireland and Spain showed over the two legs with their excellent defence, alternatives to scoring from open play will always be important. The Indians, in that respect, are far from a finished product. It was also an area that highlighted why the Dutchmen — with their incredible accuracy of passing and trapping and ability to stretch the defence and create space — are at the top of the table and lost only one game in regulation time here.

The Indian forwards did well to get their chances but they were also guilty of wasting them. Akashdeep Singh, the perennial potential star, continued to score a few but miss a lot. Along with Lalit Upadhyay, he is one of the seniormost members of the side but remains unsure of his spot in the team and the Pro League showed why.

With the likes of Abhishek, Sukhjeet and Sanjay impressing with their creativity and initiatives inside the circle, time is running out for the senior pros to impress coach Craig Fulton. Having missed the bus for Tokyo, Akashdeep — ironically, perhaps, the most naturally talented of the lot — would be hoping his luck turns soon.

The defence was equally solid but again had moments when it struggled to stay structured and calm, especially when up against



THE EMOTIONAL OUTBURST BY COACH JANNEKE SCHOPMAN, FOLLOWED BY HER RESIGNATION, ONLY MADE IT WORSE FOR THE WOMEN'S HOCKEY TEAM



unstoppable forces like the Australian team. The first match between the two was a 10-goal fest that saw India come back from deficit to take the lead, only to see it melt away towards the end. It was proof that the legs needed to be faster still, the stamina increased even more and the fitness taken up another notch.

The beating heart of the team, however, remains the midfield. Between them, Hardik Singh, Sumit, Vivek and Manpreet kept the team running all through. They exchanged positions, shifted places as needed, moved up and down, left to right, through the middle and the flanks, constantly keeping the team moving and creating chances.

Goalscorers may be the stars in the spotlight but if India wants to still be in action come August 8, it will want the goal-creators to come good. And the goalkeeper — the one position where there will be no back-up with the choice between PR Sreejesh and Krishan Pathak getting tougher by the day — to step up.

The women, however, continued



to struggle. They did end their losing streak and win two of the eight games — and one in SO — but the problem of creating chances and not converting them remained. Physically, the Indian women proved they were a match for the best in the business — keeping pace with the Dutchwomen and the Australians for entire games — and held their own defensively. But in the end, it's the goals that count. And while the men boast of perhaps the biggest bench in drag-flick, the women's cupboard lies bare, with Gurjit a shadow of her old self and Deepika not yet there.

What the Pro League also confirmed was there was no substitute for experience. Vandana Katariya, the fulcrum of most Indian attacks over the past decade, had rarely missed a tournament until the Olympic Qualifiers, which she missed due to a freak cheekbone injury during training.

Her return made the Indian attack suddenly sharper, stronger